Two Columns

The river runs through the middle of the town and divides it into two very different halves. On the northern bank the streets are narrow and steep, lined with tall houses painted in faded blue and yellow. Market day is Thursday, and the square fills with stalls selling bread, cheese, wool and copper pots.

On the southern bank everything is newer. The railway station opened forty years ago, and around it grew a neighbourhood of wide avenues, small factories and gardens with fruit trees. People there say the north is beautiful but impractical; people in the north say the south is practical but has no soul.

Every evening, when the bells ring at six, both halves meet on the old stone bridge. Fishermen sell the last of their catch, students play music, and for an hour nobody cares which bank they were born on.